| FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF |

History across the world has shown that the greatest of men who were treated like Gods by their citizens were eventually found to have feet of clay. That's the ultimate political paradox. This time in India, a powerful statement at the voting booths brought that diminution of stature. If it looks like a mixed mandate and not an emphatic one, that is precisely what it is meant to be. It is a correction of excess, a tempering, a recalibration. Instead of handing another blank cheque to the Narendra Modi dispensation, another gift of superabundance, the voters favoured moderation.

Democracy, by definition, is 'the rule of the people'. Governments must heed their collective will. Indeed, the Indian electorate is a great teacher. Here are some of the lessons of the 2024 election:

- Don't take the voter for granted. The BJP's "*char sau paar*" slogan may have been a war cry, but for many, it seemed like something preordained, which was unacceptable to them. For Indians, their vote is sacred and is their inalienable right.
- Modi is still an extremely popular leader, but the BJP can no longer rely exclusively on the Modi magic. It must nurture other regional leaders to increase its numbers.
- Vote banks are not monolithic. They can shift or combine to change the political landscape. In this election, new caste combinations emerged across the Hindi heartland. In Haryana, Dalits and Jats voted alongside each other for the first time in the post-Devi Lal era. East Rajasthan saw a rare convergence of Jat-Meena-Gujjar-Jatav voters. In Uttar Pradesh, Dalits voted alongside Yadavs for the first time in three decades. The BJP tally in SC reserved seats dropped from 46 in 2019 to 30 now. Maharashtra even coined the acronym 'Ma-Mu': Marathas and Muslims voting together! All this organic social engineering damaged the "*char sau paar*" narrative.
- Even women cannot be treated as one neatly separable bloc, the assumption on which all parties have been assiduously courting them. They are hardly unconnected to the fate of men. Women can vote differently from men, but women can also vote differently from other women. It is wrong to assume direct transfers or other women-centric sops will attract them en masse. What worked for Mamata Banerjee didn't work for Arvind Kejriwal or Jagan Mohan Reddy.
- The politics of aggressive Hindutva nationalism has reached its limit. It probably has a negative effect on the moderate Hindu swing voter. The defeat of the BJP in Ayodhya, the new 'Vatican for Hindus', signals that unambiguously. Add to that the 68 per cent reduction in the prime minister's victory margin in the holy city of Varanasi. Hopefully, the sell-by date of divisive politics has expired.
- Fighting corruption is laudable, but not when it is selective. For example, welcoming defectors with serious corruption charges against them and not pursuing their cases. Out of the BJP's 43 defector candidates, only 14 won; and only five out of 28 won for the Congress.
- Breaking up political opponents' parties is frowned upon, as shown in the INDIA bloc tally of 30 out of 48 seats in Maharashtra, where the BJP splintered two regional parties.
- The issue of the much-reviled EVMs being rigged is buried. Elections in India are free and fair.
- The myth of the TINA or There Is No Alternative factor has been broken. There is now TIFA. There Is a Federal Alternative. Coinage courtesy Kapil Sibal.
- The main issue was unemployment and inflation. However, it has been there in every election in recent memory. The difference was that the BJP barely acknowledged it. The lack of jobs and the prices of everyday items affects everyone. Dole is like taking your citizens for granted and is not sufficient. The '*labharthis*' are not going to be satisfied with 5 kg of free ration. They want jobs so that they can lead a life of dignity. The competitive welfarism being practised by all parties is a race to the bottom for the country.
- Related to jobs is the reservation issue, which is enshrined in the Constitution. The misleading narrative by the INDIA bloc that the BJP's 400-seat target was aimed at changing the Constitution to eliminate reservations gained considerable traction and affected Dalit and OBC votes. This issue is not going away, as the promoter of the caste census is part of the winning alliance.
- Rural distress clearly affected voting patterns. The BJP lost 49 of the 198 rural seats it held; the Congress added 26 to its previous tally of 29. The farmers obviously felt neglected by Modi 2.0.
- Finally, the voter has said that the sibling of being powerful must be humility, otherwise you fall on your own sword.

Besides all these factors, there is the intangible. The pervasive sense of fear in society. People talk in whispers in drawing rooms. When meeting government ministers, even in private conversations, they switch off their phones and ask you to do the same. Business people fear getting on the wrong side of the government. Academics are afraid of

